would have been entirely unwelcome to the Uzbeks as the most powerful clan with the largest assigned lands and would have been a sign, for them, of a new dawn.

In 1564, in the middle of the monsoon season, Akbar set off for an elephant hunt in the Narwar forests of Malwa. With lightning flashing across the lowering skies, the Mughal train made its way across the slippery mud, through sheets of rain, crossing the foaming Chambal River till it reached Gwalior. In the forests around Gwalior, ‘in which human had never set foot’ carpenters built wood scaffolding over which tents were stretched and carpets were laid out on the floor for the emperor. These tracts of largely uninhabited forests were notoriously lawless, as noted by the Jesuit Monserrate, who wrote that their ‘savage inhabitants, knowing that they can commit robberies with impunity, are wont to attack travellers from ambush and to carry off their goods as plunder’.

Around the imperial tent, the Padshah’s closest companions and kokas pitched their own tents and, in the watery dawn, Akbar listened to Darbar Khan narrate a rousing episode from the *Hamzanama*. The men then set off on foot in every direction to capture wild elephants. When wild elephants were spotted, they were chased on tame elephants, all day, till the exhausted beasts were lassoed and captured. This was an early example of the use of so-called ‘Judas’ beasts, tame animals that were used to lure and capture their wild counterparts and Akbar would use them in innovative ways. Gentleness was then essential, wrote Abu’l Fazl, so that ‘by giving it straw, grain and water appropriate to its nature’, the captured animal could be calmed. One day, as the hunters made their way through forest so thick that light barely filtered through the canopy, a herd of seventy wild elephants was spotted, to Akbar’s delight; the animals were captured and each was tied to a different tree. Finally, since Akbar ‘desired to hunt some more wild beasts’, as Abu’l Fazl meaningfully wrote, the emperor exposed the true reason behind this expedition and rode off towards Mandu to confront one of the Uzbek chieftains, Abdullah Khan Uzbek, Governor of Malwa. In the scouring rain the horses ‘swam like sea horses and the camels crossed the floods like ocean-going ships’. By the time they neared Mandu, only Munim Khan, Aziz Khan Koka and a few other amirs’ tents had arrived, the imperial retinue having got hopelessly bogged down in the shifting mud. Finally, when a small retinue of men, including the qissa-khwan, Darbar Khan, and the eunuch, Itimad Khan, were sent to Abdullah Khan Uzbek